

“SUSE enhances your skill sets in Linux such as scripting, GUI, etc, while RHCE only gives the basic skill sets of Linux.”

— Sanjeev Bali, an NCLP, RHCE, NCLE, NCLA professional and Certified Novell Instructor for SUSE 10 and 11

From the point of view of training and preparation for the certification, Red Hat has a large network of 100-plus training partners, making it the most accessible certification training in India. Nevertheless, Novell is known for better training standards. “Red Hat has little norms in place for qualifying the trainers at partner institutions. Compared to this, Novell allows only Certified Novell Instructors (CNIs) to train participants. As such, the training standards for Novell programs are considerably higher compared to Red Hat,” says Prasad.

Comprehensive understanding and adaptability

For professionals planning a career shift from proprietary software to open source, both RHCE and NCLP have strong yet different value propositions. If you want to first understand Linux completely, and then jump at achieving career growth, NCLP is a good choice. “Novell certifications make a professional more adaptable in mixed-environment scenarios, where cross-functional ability and interoperability are key to career progression. We know that mixed environments are a reality, and that customers are going to run both open-source and proprietary software in their enterprise data centre or client-side environment. Our focus on interoperability and the co-existence of both these environments, with the mission of “making it work as one,” positions us well in today’s challenging IT environment. This makes Novell’s training and certification ideally suited for anybody aspiring to have a technical career that spans open source as well as proprietary technologies,” says Menon. “A person wanting a career shift from proprietary to open source should first undergo NCLP, which is based on SUSE Linux and supports most proprietary software out-of-the-box, making it an easier path for professionals shifting from proprietary to open source,” adds Bali. Unlike other flavours of Linux, proprietary products like .NET, SAP and some Windows 2003 applications are supported on SUSE Linux.

Further, in RHCE, everything centres around the use of the textual user interface (TUI)—the console, or a terminal—making it difficult for a newbie. Instead, in SUSE Linux certifications, you can either go with the TUI or a graphical user interface (GUI), which many find easier and more efficient. NCLP is also preferred because of the good documentation

that comes with SUSE Linux. “Documentation is very important in Linux usage, because once a candidate gets stuck with any question in the certification exam, the available documentation might come in handy, and help the candidate clear the certification. Most configuration files in SUSE Linux are well documented with comments and suggested configuration lines, whereas in Red Hat the important configuration files are not that well documented,” says Sharan. “NCLP shows the migration path from Microsoft to Linux. The look and feel of SUSE is more or less like Windows, and it comes with many tools preconfigured to integrate with Windows, which we have to do some tucking for in Red Hat Linux,” adds Maniyar.

However, if you have an eye on the job market, an RHCE certification could be a better choice, as it has a higher market value than the NCLP. “Red Hat, undoubtedly, has the largest installation base for Linux in India. With a large number of UNIX-dependent organisations also recognising RHCE certifications, the RHCE becomes the best option for those shifting from proprietary to open source technology,” says Bhaskaran.

So is a combo a winning deal?

Many professionals suggest a combination of both certifications to increase one’s knowledge and reach in the market. Speaking from personal experience, Sharan says: “Once I finished my RHCE, job offers in the systems administration domain were restricted to a single platform, Red Hat. But once I got the NCLP certification, I was qualified to work on multiple Linux platforms, along with the added advantage of shell-scripting knowledge. This improved my employability and knowledge.” Says Aggarwal, “Professionals planning their careers can opt for one vendor’s certification first, and later on, add the other one. This approach needs less effort, and adds more career growth opportunities.”

Baskar adds: “An RHCE is the most preferred professional to handle Linux-based environments, and also UNIX-based environments to some extent. Besides, the RHCE examination methodology is most appreciated in the IT industry. However, shell scripting is one important aspect for a systems administrator, which is not given importance in RHCE. Hence, a combo deal of both would be good for a Linux aspirant.” Novell has foreseen this, because it offers a bridge course from RHCE to NCLP to professionals wishing to benefit from both certifications.

In a nutshell, certifications from both Red Hat and Novell are equally promising. With the relative merits of each certification detailed here, you should now be able to choose which one (or which combination!) is a better fit for your intended career path! 

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The author loves to experiment, and writing for LINUX For You is her latest experiment—so beware! Just a minute, she also happens to be a journalist during the day.